

HSC English: Student Draft

“A fond memory brings you a wave of comfort and ignites the senses. It’s the kind of memory you can visualise and describe in rich detail.”

Using the stimulus above, craft an imaginative or discursive piece of writing that captures the richness of a fond memory.

HOW TO READ THE SAMPLE Black = retained text Gold underlined = tutor addition Gold strikethrough = suggested removal

STUDENT DRAFT + LIVE EDITS	FULL TUTOR COMMENTS
The yellow street light <u>cast a faint</u> glowed as Vu stepped off the bus. <u>Across</u> The other side of the road, a narrow is the alley <u>led</u> to his house. Cautiously, he dodged the passing bikers and crossed to the other side. <u>As he reached</u> Reaching the front gate, warm festoon lights welcomed him home, Vu was greeted with the warm festoon lights hanging by the gates, the same lights that saw him leave.	Sentence-level edits are shown directly in the draft.
<u>Looking i</u>	Sentence-level edits are shown directly in the draft.
<u>Inside,</u> he stared at the <u>fluorescent fire crackling beneath a large pot burning log that lit up the pot</u> filled with Vietnamese sticky rice cake that <u>had been</u> was simmering for hours. The aroma grew stronger as Vu slowly approached. <u>He lifted the lid, and a cloud of steam curled towards his face.</u> the pot and opened the lid. The hot smoke curled up on his face, iInstinctively, he flinched back and closed the lid. Memories <u>flooded</u>flood through his <u>mind-head,</u> jostling to the surface, desperate to be <u>remembered-seen.</u> The <u>sweet</u> smell of the rice cake <u>clung to the walls,</u> lingeredlingers in the night, reminding him of the moment that belongs to another time, his eyes rested on the crackling fire, the sounds around him slowly faded. He stood there perfectly still, his gaze fixed on the pot as memory pulled him away from the present. ^[1]	1 SPECIFICITY Can you be more specific here?
In the moment of silence, a voice echoed through the crackling wood.	Sentence-level edits are shown directly in the draft.
“Ai đó” (who’s there?) <u>his mother called abruptly.</u> said with an alert tone ^[2]	2 DIALOGUE Always clarify who is speaking the dialogue.
A footstep h<u>Hurried footsteps thumped</u> out of the kitchen,; his mum froze for a second, her eyes <u>narrowed in disbelief</u> tightly squinted while her face lit up <u>with a radiant bright</u> smile. Wasting no time, she quickly rushed forward and <u>embraced squeezed</u> Vu tightly in her arms, with all her strength. The sharp <u>stench</u> seent of fish sauce on her shirt <u>filled his</u> flushed up his nose. The quick hug became a squeeze along the arm, in disbelief of seeing his presence. Worrying that Vu <u>was</u> hungry, <u>she guided him towards the wooden table and hurried back to the kitchen, carrying out bowls and plates of steaming food.</u> she sat him down and rushed to lay food on the table. ^[3]	3 TONE & WORD CHOICE This sounds too forceful, which contrasts with the gentle and heartfelt moment you are trying to create.
“Ông ơi, ra ăn cơm với thằng Vũ nè” (honey, come out and eat dinner with Vu) ^[4]	4 RELEVANCE This dialogue does not add much; consider removing it.

STUDENT DRAFT + LIVE EDITS	FULL TUTOR COMMENTS
As Vu sat at the dinner table, a rough hand rested on his shoulder. Seeing Vu at the dinner table, Vu felt a rough hand rested on his shoulder before turning around and hugging his dad so tight that it squeezed the breath out of him. Years of separation disappeared within a single embrace. Vu and his Daddad clutched the chopsticks in their hands while Mumum filled each bowl with steaming rice. Thin ribbons of smoke rosearise from the <i>thịt kho hột vịt</i>, carrying the rich scent of fish sauce that he hadn'thasn't had a chance to savor in years. The aroma lingered in the warm evening, pulling him back to memories that he thought he had forgotten. Once everyone's bowl was filled, chopsticks immediately began darting across the table, and the chatting began, with every topic finding its way to - somehow always coming back to Vu. Hands reached across the table, picking up slices of pork, herbs, and bitter melon before dropping themit in Vu's bowl, and before he could resistt, another piece of food was dropped in his bowl. In the loud chatting, a raspy voice roserises. ^{[5][6]}	5 TENSE CONTROL Be careful with tense; you have a tendency to switch between past and present. 6 DEVELOPMENT This is a little vague. Consider adding a brief flashback of him as a young boy—tapping his chopsticks or kicking his feet beneath the table.
“Con dạo này ăn uống được không là ốm dữ vậy con” (have you been eating well? You look so skinny) Mumum asked worriedly. ^[7]	7 PUNCTUATION Where is the question mark in this sentence?
Vu stared at her. The question was suspended in the air, louder than the conversations around them. his mum for a moment, her question hanging in the air longer than the noise around them. Vu lowered his gaze head to looking down at his bowl; the lie slipped from out of his mouth before he could stop it.	<i>Sentence-level edits are shown directly in the draft.</i>
“Con có ăn nhiều mà” (I do eat a lot), he answered softly.	<i>Sentence-level edits are shown directly in the draft.</i>
The answer was simple, almost automatic. Around him, the table still continued its the rhythm, hands moving, mouths chewing munching, chopsticks clinking against ceramic bowlss, each taking turns to ask him questions. While next to them, the rice cake continuedcontinues to simmer, slowly binding together everything time has tried to pull apart. ^[8] ^[9]	8 VOICE This sounds too childlike for the tone of the piece. 9 CLARITY This idea is a little abstract. Ground it in a concrete sensory detail or action.
After dinner, the rice cake was ready to serve. Everyoneeveryone in the family sat in a circle around, surrounding the steaming pot, holding a plate, waiting for Mumumum to serve give them their piece. Steam rose around them, softening the wrinkles on his parents' faces until they became the people that Vu remembered as a child. The rice cake tasted exactly as it was years ago, not because the recipe did not change, but because that was the taste of family, the unalterable taste that stayed the same for years. With each bite of the savory rice cake, the sense of home gradually grew, filling the emptiness that years away from home had quietly carved away from him. ^{[10][11]}	10 MODELLED EXAMPLE For example: <i>“The sticky rice clung softly to his tongue, warm and slightly sweet. He had eaten rice cakes from street vendors while he was away, wrapped neatly in banana leaves and reheated by the microwave. They were warm beneath his fingertips but cold at the centre, their rice dry and their filling bland.</i> But this one was different. Vu took another bite and let the warmth settle inside him. For the first time in years, he did not feel the need to search for what was missing.” 11 SHOW, DON'T TELL This is too telling. Describe how the flavour coats his mouth—warm, sweet and familiar. You could contrast it with rice cakes bought away from home: warm on the outside, cold in the centre and bland.

Feedback moves beyond correction: it models stronger expression, explains why choices are ineffective and gives the student a practical next step.